

Right sizing

This is property parlance for buying the most appropriately sized home for your stage of life. It was coined as an alternative phrase to ‘downsizing’, which is what baby boomers do when they cash in their large family home and move to a smaller property for retirement, and bank the rest. But it should also become the mantra of the first home buyer, if you want to get a toe on the property ladder.

Right sizing, says Sally Capp, executive director of the Victorian division of the Property Council of Australia, ‘is about transition, not about downgrading your life or your accommodation. Right sizing is the adjustments you make to your accommodation as your life changes.’ There are more rungs on the property ladder now than there used to be, Capp says, compared to the era in which our parents were buying. Then, they likely purchased the home where they would raise children and remain for decades to come. That era is over. ‘First home buyers have traditionally been trying to buy a house, and that concept is typically what they think they will need over the next 20 years, [but] that is not actually how people operate these days,’ Capp says.

Where you work is still a lead criterion for where to buy, rather than how many children you might have, or getting a ‘footprint’ in a leafy suburb where you aspire to live in decades’ time. Hand in hand with that is prioritising education (your future children’s schooling), medical services, libraries and family-friendly parks with play equipment. These could all be considerations for life’s next phase.

Regardless of what and where you buy, these are some tried-and-tested aspects to tick off your list at any ‘open for inspection’:

1. Adaptable floor plan

You don’t need a luxuriously large amount of space – just adaptable space. A floorplan that includes a second room for a study or bedroom, and outdoor area that can be enhanced to